IGNACIO LÓPEZ RIVAS

Technical Combat Designer | Enemy AI | Unreal Engine

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Technical Combat Designer with AAA experience on The Lords of the Fallen (2023) and recent NPC combat work at Virtuos on an unannounced AAA action title. Specialized in enemy AI and encounter design in Unreal Engine: Behavior Trees, State Trees, EQS, AI Perception, Gameplay Ability System and data-driven tuning. Experienced in first-person and third-person combat, in building custom tools, and in writing specs that programmers, animators, VFX and audio teams can act on. Based in Kraków, open to relocation.

SKILLS

- **Combat AI:** Behavior Trees, State Trees, EQS, AI Perception, Gameplay Ability System, Blueprints, Data Assets, encounter design, TTK/cooldown balancing, enemy briefs, behavior specs, tuning sheets
- **Engines:** Unreal Engine 4/5 (Blueprints, C++, AI, UMG, Animation), Unity (C#)
- **Design:** Combat Design, Enemy Design, Level Design, System Design, Gameplay Prototyping, Audio Integration
- **Tools and process:** Git, Plastic SCM, Jira, Trello, Agile, Scrum (PSM I)
- **Other:** Python (Pandas, NumPy, Scikit-learn), Adobe Photoshop & Illustrator, MS Office

EXPERIENCE

Technical Designer (Freelance) – Virtuos
Remote, Kraków, Poland | Nov 2025 – Present

- Designed, implemented and tuned combat AI for regular enemies found in open-world encounters, for bosses, and for an allied NPC that fights alongside the player, on an unannounced AAA action title.
- Tuned perception, target selection, attack, cooldown and difficulty parameters through a data-driven setup; implemented many NPC skills end to end with animation, VFX and audio, and reworked and fixed many others.
- Built a custom animation-retiming tool for an in-house engine and a unified designer–animator feedback template for the design teams.
- Wrote behavior specs and cross-team proposals (VFX, navmesh) and presented work to client stakeholders.

Master's Degree Teacher – Universidad Europea de Madrid
Madrid, Spain | Mar 2024 – Present

- Teach enemy AI (Behavior Trees, AI Perception) and gameplay prototyping in Unreal Engine 5, mentor student projects and create course content.

Mid Programmer, UE5 Specialist – SNGULAR
Madrid, Spain | Jun 2023 – Jan 2024

- UI implementation and C++ tools programming in Unreal Engine 5, including a JSON importer into Unreal.

Technical Designer / Combat Designer – Xaloc Studios
Palma de Mallorca, Spain | Jun 2021 – Dec 2022

- Credited as Combat Designer on The Lords of the Fallen (2023); also worked as Technical and Level Designer during the last 10 months of the project, in close collaboration with the Creative Director, Executive Producer, Lead Designer, Lead Programmer, animators and sound designers.
- Designed boss encounters end to end: enemy AI (Behavior Trees, State Trees, EQS, AI Perception, Gameplay Ability System), phases, attack types, animation tuning, telegraphing, balancing and sound integration, all data-driven.
- Bosses: Tancred, Master of Castigations; Adyr, the Bereft Exile (including the Adyr worshipper enemy and the full level, designed from scratch with the environment team); The Hollow Crow. MoCap sessions for Adyr and The Hollow Crow.
- Before LoTF, designed and pitched several products: a level editor, a mobile life simulator, a puzzle-adventure game for kids and a roguelike beat'em up.
- Interviewed game design candidates and mentored junior designers.

Solo Game Developer – Lazy Golf
Castellón, Spain | Sep 2020 – Dec 2020

- Designed, developed and published a mobile game independently.

Technical Designer – Lost Criteria Studios (Blackstorm)
Madrid, Spain | Feb 2019 – Jun 2020

- Co-founded with 17 Master's classmates (team of 18) the studio behind Blackstorm, a first-person game, started as a Master's project at U-tad and finished independently.
- Game design: wrote design documents for several features (including the inventory) and designed the cannon/weapon system and the behavior of each weapon.
- Technical design: implemented gameplay features and scalable systems in Unreal Engine 4, including weapon systems and multiplayer mechanics prototypes.
- Sound design: created and integrated the game's audio.
- Ran live playtests with players at industry fairs, observing play and collecting feedback.
- Released on Steam on 1 June 2021. Winner of PlayStation Talents Spain (Best Press Game) and Fun & Serious (New Talents Prize), 2019.

Game Development Intern – Bambo Studio
Málaga, Spain | Mar 2017 – May 2017

- Built a mobile music game that parsed MIDI files to generate levels procedurally.

EDUCATION

- Master's Degree in Game Design – U-tad, University of Technology, Arts and Design | Oct 2018 – Oct 2019
- Bachelor's in Game Development & Design – Jaume I University | Sep 2013 – Jul 2017

CERTIFICATIONS

- Professional Scrum Master™ I – Scrum.org | Jan 2023
- Complete A.I. & Machine Learning, Data Science Bootcamp – Udemy | Aug 2025

LANGUAGES

- Spanish: Native
- English: Fluent (IELTS 7.0)
- French: Elementary

AWARDS

- 2019 | PlayStation Talents Spain – Best Press Game, Blackstorm
- 2019 | Fun & Serious – New Talents Prize, Blackstorm
- 2018 | 1st Prize Hackathon Castellón – Best Videogame